EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Do the Righteous Suffer?

Given Monday 20 January 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 5:2-3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 5 (Merits and Demerits), the end of Chapter 2 and the first part of Chapter 3, with the Rambam's Moreh Nevuchim 3:22-23 on Iyov

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 20 January 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Majority and the Minority

The book so far: Essay 1 on creation, Essay 2 on God, Essay 3 on Torah and revelation, Essay 4 on free will. Essay 5 is about how we serve God and the consequences of our deeds.

From Chapter 1: Hashem remembers everything, and every action leaves an impression on the soul, so that two people can do outwardly identical things, one permitted and one forbidden, with starkly different effects on their souls. Everything is paid in full in the Olam HaBa that Hashem will create (unlike the Rambam's view, that Olam HaBa already coexists with this world).

From Chapter 2: there are ten **categories** of people ("not ten levels, ten categories"). A **tzaddik** has more merits than demerits; a **rasha** has more demerits than merits. **The majority is repaid in the world to come; the minority in this world.** So the tzaddik's sins are dealt with here, and the rasha's mitzvot are rewarded here.

Last week the class asked why the rasha's mitzvot should be repaid in this finite world. The Rabbi's answer: his are not *olam haba* mitzvot. They are done with ulterior motives and not fully. That is why the Rambam writes that **one mitzvah done fully, genuinely and sincerely earns a portion in the world to come**: such a deed can only be repaid there. "I'm not entirely sure if Saadia would agree with that," but Saadia's weighing of the majority "can be perhaps compatible with the Rambam's identity approach" learnt on Tuesday nights.

Tonight: the rest of Chapter 2 and Chapter 3, Saadia's theodicy, "and then we will see the Rambam's understanding based on the book of Iyov."

What about the flourishing tzaddik?

A participant asked: if the tzaddik's sins are paid here, how can we ever see a tzaddik flourishing, with everything going well? The Rabbi offered two possibilities: either such a person is entirely perfect, a *shalem*, so that everything goes well in both worlds; or, better, everyone has some suffering, "we don't know the exact suffering a person has," and his

inconveniences here and there are the payment for his few bad deeds, while overall he flourishes.

A Word of Caution Before Theodicy

"There's one thing I want to say before we do this, which Saadia doesn't say. The Rambam, to the best of my knowledge, doesn't say this, but later authorities say this, and I think there's so much truth to it." The Rabbi said Rav Dessler states it explicitly, though it surely precedes him:

We are learning **general** theodicy. We must be very careful never to apply it to particular people. "Whatever we learn in Saadia tonight, or in the Rambam in the Moreh, we can't now start viewing people through the lens of Saadia and the Moreh and say, he's going through this because of that."

The Mishnah already tells us we have no idea who is a tzaddik and who is a rasha. Some people seem good and are not; some seem not to be decent people and have things we are not aware of.

"I've given many, many shiurim on the whole concept of theodicy and all the different approaches. And yet when people ask me, why does this happen to me or to him or to her, I don't use these approaches... No one can answer such a question. Really only HaKadosh Baruch Hu can."

A participant connected this to **Rabbi Yannai** in Pirkei Avot: **אין בידינו לא משלות הרשעים ואף לא מיסורי הצדיקים**, "it is not in our hands to explain the tranquillity of the wicked or the suffering of the righteous." The participant had always translated it as the *seeming* suffering of the righteous. The Rabbi checked the text and said the word "seemingly" is not there, though some commentators surely say so, and the idea is true. Another participant added that each person has a potential known only to Hashem: someone very good may reach eight out of ten when he should have reached ten. "Which is why we cannot judge anyone, for the good or for the bad. And the only way we can answer is to look into ourselves, not what's happening to them."

Chapter 2 Continued: Regretting Good Deeds

Saadia: everything said so far about the majority applies **when a person has no regret**. But:

- **If he did many mitzvot and regretted them, he loses them through his regret. ובשוב צדיק מצדקתו ועשה עול... כל צדקתו אשר עשה לא תזכרנה**, "when a righteous man turns from his righteousness... none of his righteousness will be remembered." The Gemara explains this as one who **regrets** his good deeds.
- **If he did many sins, regretted them and fulfilled the conditions of repentance, he is rid of them**: **ובשוב רשע מרשעתו... כל פשעיו אשר עשה לא יזכרו לו**.

"Isn't this a bit shocking? You do a good deed, and you regret it, you've lost that deed. I find that very difficult. The Gemara does say that."

An asymmetry in the text

The Rabbi pointed out something in Saadia's wording. Later in this essay (Chapters 6 or 7), Saadia sets out the process of teshuvah: regret, a commitment for the future and the rest. Here:

	What Saadia requires to lose it
Mitzvot	**Regret alone.** "Full stop. The regret itself makes you lose them."
Sins	**Regret and fulfilling the process of teshuvah**

Take a simple case. A person gives charity. A week later he loses a lot of money and says, "I wish I had never given that money." He has not resolved never to give again; he just regrets it. Is that enough to lose the mitzvah?

If so, it would seem that mitzvot are easier to lose than sins, "which would be theologically very difficult," since we have always been taught that Hashem's kindness and reward are greater than His punishment. Or perhaps Saadia only spells out the process for sins because we are more familiar with teshuvah, and the same process would be needed to lose a mitzvah. "I'm not entirely clear what Saadia means here, but I think this is a very important point to bring out."

Suggestions from the class

- **Mark:** regretting a mitzvah, as in the charity example, is really questioning Hashem: why did I lose the money? It involves **a lack of faith**, which makes it more severe and explains why no formula is needed. The Rabbi: "Interesting. So you're saying every regret of a mitzvah has an element of lack of faith… I have to think about that." Later in the text Saadia indeed calls the regret **denial** (*kefirah*): "It's interesting, Mark, he uses that word."
- **Doron**, connecting to Tuesday nights: a mitzvah **builds** something positive in your identity; "it's not some sort of candy counter." Regretting it disconnects you from what you built. A sin needs a process for the future, because merely regretting it doesn't stop anything.
- **Another participant:** a mitzvah has an immediate merit and a **continuing** merit, credited to you as long as you stand behind it. Regret withdraws you from the good intention.

The Rabbi: "All three of your things are agreeing with each other." He heard the identity idea but was again "reluctant to impose the Rambam's ideas on Saadia," though he said he had found some indications over the week that Saadia may accept it.

The burglary and Shacharit

"I'm not giving an answer to this. Just appreciate the following scenario." I got up early, said Shema and prayed in shul. Then I found out that while I was in shul my house was burgled. "I should never have gone to synagogue." I regret it, so I have lost the mitzvah. It is now 8:30 and there is still time for Shacharit. **Am I now obliged to pray again?** And if I then regret my regret?

In teshuvah, as the Rambam's Hilchot Teshuvah puts it very strongly, the sin is **uprooted**: it is gone from a person's identity, so much so that one may not remind him of it. Is the lost mitzvah the same?

- A participant: there was a **forfeiture**. The action happened; what is lost is the merit, the identity building. There is no new obligation.
- The Rabbi agreed, and then wondered aloud whether teshuvah works the same way. "You can't rewrite history. The deed has been done. Even when you do teshuvah, the deed is there... Anything associated to that is completely wiped out." That is why part of teshuvah is repairing what one can in this world: a thief must return what he stole. "It doesn't mean you didn't steal."

The practical lesson

"What's key here is for us to appreciate how important it is to take pride and enjoyment in the good which we do in life, and not, chas veshalom, to regret it."

But if the charity turned out to be dishonest, that is a legitimate regret. "Hashem didn't command me to give to dishonest institutions. I regret that I was duped, and that's fine... be more vigilant in the future."

When fortunes reverse

Saadia continues:

- A person whose merits are the majority, with his reward prepared in the world to come, begins to regret his good deeds, to **deny**. His merits are knocked off, and Hashem pays some of them in this world. People see that as soon as he became a heretic, the good life began, "and this can actually cause people to sin." But the truth is that the good he receives now is the reward that would have been his in the next world.
- Conversely, a person with a majority of demerits begins to mend his ways, and just then everything goes badly for him. People are astonished. But it is not because he started doing good. His past sins must now be dealt with, and Hashem decides to do it in this world.

"When you think about this, you will get rid of any doubts," Saadia says, "and strengthen your heart for service."

The Rabbi summed it up: "Mending a person's ways can actually sometimes lead to misfortune in this world, and vice versa. A person leaving the path of HaKadosh Baruch Hu... can actually lead to many benefits and enjoyment of the pleasures of this world."

Each deed separately

Finally Saadia addresses a question: how can one regret undo many mitzvot? He answers that it is incorrect to think so: **each deed must be regretted separately**. Likewise, one act of repentance does not wipe out all one's sins; each must be repented. "It's not just you change one way and everything changes."

Chapter 3: Why the Righteous Suffer

Saadia gives "two explanations, two slash three. It's two and a half."

1. Payment for the minority

As in Chapter 2: the majority of a tzaddik's deeds are rewarded in the next world, and his minority of sins is dealt with in this one.

2. A test the person can bear

Hashem brings misfortune on a person **when He knows the person can endure it**, and then rewards him for enduring: **ה' צדיק יבחן**, "Hashem tests the righteous." He does not generally give such tests to people who will not withstand them.

The question is: will your faith be impaired by the suffering, or will you remain strong, steadfast and loyal? The Rabbi noted that Saadia generally portrays **Iyov** as a good person who accepted what Hashem gave him; the Rambam, as the class would see, disagrees.

The Midrash of the flax. When good quality flax is pressed and pounded, its quality improves. Bad flax, when struck, simply breaks. So Hashem gives this test only to the righteous.

Does Hashem tell you why?

Saadia makes a further distinction:

- **Suffering for sins:** when a person asks why, it is customary for Hashem to tell him, as in **על מה עשה ה' ככה**, "why has Hashem done this?", which is followed by the answer "because they forsook the covenant." Knowing the reason encourages teshuvah.
- **Suffering as a test:** generally Hashem does not tell him. Saadia's example is **Moshe**, who asked Hashem why this was happening; "I'm critical of Moshe's question here," Saadia says. On Saadia's reading Moshe's suffering was a test to increase his reward, and he was not told the reason. That is fitting: "the whole purpose of this test is, are you going to stand strong in your faith. If I tell you that I'm testing you, then there's no point in it."

"Has anyone ever tried it and it's worked? I'm sure many of us, when going through difficult times in life, have asked HaKadosh Baruch Hu why, and we don't always get the answer." The Rabbi's own suggestion, "purely, I have no proof of this," based on the Gemara in Berachot, which links the nature of the suffering to the sin being rectified: perhaps Saadia means that the explanation is latent in the form the suffering takes. "As I said, I don't fully understand this, because I haven't always experienced this."

2½. To increase reward

"Furthermore," Saadia says, **even a person who is complete** may sometimes suffer, not as a test, but purely **to increase his reward in the next world**.

His proof: **infants**. Babies suffer great illnesses and pain, and sometimes die. It cannot be for sins, and it cannot be a test, "because you can't test a one year old." It must be to increase their reward. The suffering of the good is for their good, like a parent who pushes a child roughly out of the path of a car, or gives him bitter medicine for his health.

The Rabbi believes this is how Saadia understands **יסורין של אהבה**, sufferings of love. The Gemara says that if a person sees suffering come upon him he should examine his deeds; if he finds nothing, they are sufferings of love.

Saadia says the same elsewhere: in Essays 6 and 8 he uses it to explain why **the children in the Flood** died, and why **the children of Midian** were killed (in Parashat Matot-Masei), though they had done nothing wrong. They are compensated in the next world.

"Theologically I don't understand this. I don't know how this works. I'll be honest with you, I much prefer the Rambam's approach, that sufferings come for a reason."

How does suffering cleanse sin?

The Rabbi added something he said he should have explained earlier: what is the mechanism by which suffering wipes away sin?

The Gemara in **Berachot** says: **נאמר ברית במלח ונאמר ברית ביסורין**. "Covenant" is said of salt, and "covenant" is said of suffering. Just as salt sweetens meat, suffering cleanses a person of his sins. The **Maharsha** explains it beautifully. Salt draws the blood out of the meat, and that is what gives it its taste; an expensive piece of meat without salt and seasoning is not enjoyed. A person sins with his body, and the driving force of the body is the blood, **כי הדם הוא הנפש**. Suffering, as it were, draws the blood out: it weakens the physical self and quells the passions that cause sin. "When a person is in bed, or has a serious illness, they're weaker. Then they start thinking about the serious questions of life," because the physical identity is weakened and the spiritual identity can come forward.

"So that I can understand. But how can it be that just because I suffer in this world, somehow I get some kind of reward in the next world?" That does not fit the Rambam's whole understanding of Olam HaBa, which the Tuesday class is learning.

Why not just give the reward?

Saadia asks it himself: if the suffering of an infant is only to increase his reward, why not simply give the extra reward without the suffering? He answers with what he said in the first essays about the purpose of creation: **what one has worked for is a greater reward**. Having suffered, one has earned it. "I find this all very, very difficult."

The second part of the chapter, Saadia's six explanations of why the wicked prosper (the Rabbi corrected a misprint of "seven"), was left for next week.

Reincarnation: Not Saadia's Answer

Some people, Saadia will say in Essay 6, adopted belief in **gilgul**, reincarnation, to explain the suffering of children: they are paying for a previous life. Saadia calls this absolute nonsense and takes it apart very forcefully. The Rambam did not believe in reincarnation either. The **Zohar** believes in it very strongly, and those who follow it can explain children's suffering that way.

The Rabbi said he would discuss it properly in Essay 6, but made the point now: "there is no classical or traditional source which believes in gilgul... There's no mention in Tanach, in the whole of Chazal." It became widespread and accepted because of the Zohar, "which is a whole different question as regards the authenticity and the dating of the Zohar, which is not for now."

The Belz chassid and the Rashash

To show how heated the issue is, the Rabbi told a story from his yeshiva days in Gateshead. He was friendly with a Belzer chassid, and mentioned a question asked by the **Rashash**, Rabbi Shmuel Strashun of Lithuania, whose concise and precise notes are printed at the back of the Talmud. "We don't learn the Rashash," came the answer. Why not?

The Gemara in **Bava Metzia** explains the blessing **ברוך אתה בבאך וברוך אתה בצאתך**: just as you come into the world clean and without sin, so may you leave it. On this the Rashash writes a few words: this is **a difficulty for the doctrine of reincarnation**, since according to the Zohar a person enters the world with all kinds of sins to rectify. Because of that comment, the chassid explained, a Belzer Rebbe some time ago ruled that the Rashash did not have the right hashkafah, and to this day, as the Rabbi has been told and others have confirmed, Belzer chassidim do not study his commentary on the Talmud.

Other Rishonim on the Suffering of the Righteous

- **Chovot HaLevavot** (Rabbeinu Bachya) says exactly what Saadia says, with the same three explanations: the minority of sins, a test, and increased reward.
- **The Kuzari** gives the same three and adds a fourth: a righteous person can suffer **for the sins of his ancestors**.

The Rambam: Moreh Nevuchim 3:22-23 on Iyov

"There's a really lot to get through, I'm going to go really quickly." The Rabbi translated the key points:

- The book of **Iyov** is a fascinating book that teaches much about **hashgachah**, providence.
- **Did it happen?** One of the Chachamim says **Iyov never existed and was only a parable**. Others say he did, but they disagree on when: in the time of Avraham, of Moshe, of David, or of the Babylonian exile. That very disagreement supports the view that it never happened. Either way, it deals with the question "which everyone asks, any intellectual human": why do the righteous suffer?
- **"There was a man in the land of Utz":** *Utz* is from **עצה**, counsel. The whole book is advice on how to deal with theodicy.
- **Iyov is never called wise.** He is called *tam*, upright, a good person with good deeds, but not wise, "because if he was a wise person he would not have had these questions." So for the Rambam, Iyov did not understand things properly.

The Rambam identifies the views of Iyov and his friends with the views on providence:

Speaker	View	The Rabbi's gloss
Iyov	From God's perspective the righteous and the wicked fare the same; He does not attend to human deeds	The view of Aristotle (or Epicurus). For the Rambam, Iyov really denied hashgachah, which is why the Chachamim criticised him
Eliphaz	Everything is **for sins** you have done	**The Rambam: this is the view of our Torah**
Bildad	**Compensation** (*pitzui*): if you have no sin, it is to increase your reward	Saadia's third explanation. The Rambam uses a legal word, "compensation," and does not accept it
Tzofar	You can never answer the question, because you cannot understand the will of God, any more than why the sky is blue. Accept it and move on	The view of the Arabic theologians
Elihu	A fifth approach	"A bit more complicated," left aside

The Rambam concludes very clearly that the correct approach, that of our Torah, is Eliphaz's: **there is no suffering and no death without sin**. He rejects the Gemara that four people died without sin. He rejects the idea that Hashem makes people suffer to increase their reward. So for the Rambam, *yissurin shel ahava* are simply sufferings that wipe away sins you do not know about.

This ties in with something learnt "a few months ago": Saadia held that **animals** slaughtered or made to suffer will be rewarded in the next world, and the Rambam rejected it outright. "It's not just the concept of hashgachah, it's much deeper than that. Can you reward someone just for suffering they go through? Saadia says yes... For the Rambam it doesn't work like that. Suffering is for sin, and that's it."

How the Rambam explains the suffering of babies the class did not discuss here; the Rabbi noted only that he cannot use Saadia's answer.

Summary

1. **Regret undoes deeds.** Regretting mitzvot loses them; regretting sins with full teshuvah removes them. Saadia's wording seems to require less to lose a mitzvah than a sin, which is "theologically very difficult." Take pride in your good deeds.
2. **Fortunes can reverse:** a righteous person who turns to denial may prosper, and a sinner who mends his ways may suffer, as past accounts are settled in this world. Each deed is regretted or repented separately.
3. **Saadia's reasons for the suffering of the righteous:** payment for the minority of sins; a **test** of faith given only to those who can bear it (the flax), whose reason is generally not revealed; and suffering **to increase reward**, proved from infants, which is his reading of *yissurin shel ahava*.

4. **The Gemara and Maharsha:** suffering cleanses like salt, by weakening the physical drives behind sin.
5. **Chovot HaLevavot** agrees with Saadia; the **Kuzari** adds ancestral sin. Saadia and the Rambam both reject **gilgul** as an explanation, and it has no source in Tanach or Chazal.
6. **The Rambam (Moreh 3:22-23):** Iyov is a parable; the friends represent the philosophical views; the Torah's view is Eliphaz's, that **all suffering is for sin**.
7. **Never apply theodicy to individuals.** Only Hashem knows why a particular person suffers.

Coming Up

Next week: the second half of Chapter 3, Saadia's six explanations of **why the wicked prosper**, "much easier, much simpler," and then Chapter 4.

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